

Guide 48 — Medical Assistant

Controlled English working master — Version 2.0

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What this work is

Medical assistants support physicians and other healthcare teams in outpatient clinics, medical offices, ambulatory-care settings, and related environments. In the United States, the occupation commonly combines administrative work with certain clinical tasks performed under appropriate direction or supervision.

Typical job titles may include medical assistant, clinical medical assistant, certified medical assistant, registered medical assistant, health assistant, outpatient medical assistant, or specialty-office assistant. Titles alone do not determine what a worker is legally permitted to do. State law, employer policy, training, credential status, delegation, and supervision can all affect the permitted scope.

This guide is for career exploration and preparation. It is not medical, legal, licensing, immigration, or financial advice. Before enrolling or performing a clinical task, verify the current rules that apply where you intend to train and work.

What you may do

Depending on the employer, jurisdiction, training, and authorized scope, duties may include:

- greeting and checking in patients;
- scheduling appointments and follow-up visits;
- updating demographic and insurance information;
- maintaining medical records and routine documentation;
- answering phones and routing messages;
- preparing examination or treatment rooms;
- interviewing patients for routine history information;
- measuring and recording vital signs, height, and weight;
- preparing patients for examination;
- collecting or preparing specimens when trained and authorized;
- cleaning or preparing instruments and supplies according to approved procedures;
- assisting a clinician during an examination or procedure;
- stocking and tracking medical or office supplies;
- processing routine forms, billing information, referrals, or authorizations; and
- following infection-prevention, privacy, safety, emergency, and documentation procedures.

Some medical assistants may be trained for tasks such as venipuncture, electrocardiography, injections, medication administration, dressing changes, or other hands-on procedures. **Do not assume that completing a general medical-assistant course automatically authorizes these tasks.** Authorization depends on the applicable law, employer, supervision model, training, and sometimes a separate credential.

What this job does not authorize by itself

A medical-assistant title or certificate does not by itself make a person a physician, registered nurse, licensed practical/vocational nurse, pharmacist, laboratory professional, radiologic technologist, or other licensed clinician.

Unless separately licensed and authorized, do not independently:

- diagnose a condition;
- prescribe or change medication;
- choose a treatment plan;
- give individualized medical advice outside approved instructions;
- interpret laboratory, imaging, ECG, or other diagnostic results as a clinician;
- alter a clinician's order;
- perform an invasive or restricted task without required training, authorization, delegation, and supervision; or
- represent yourself as holding a license or credential you do not actually possess.

When a patient's condition appears urgent, follow the employer's escalation and emergency procedures rather than trying to manage the situation beyond your role.

Work environment and physical demands

Medical assistants commonly work in physicians' offices, outpatient clinics, urgent-care settings, specialty practices, ambulatory centres, and other healthcare environments. Many positions are full time. Some facilities operate evenings, weekends, or holidays.

The work can involve long periods of standing or walking, frequent interaction with patients, computer use, repetitive documentation, moving supplies, assisting people with mobility, and exposure to blood, body fluids, sharps, infectious disease, cleaning chemicals, or other hazards.

Follow approved procedures for hand hygiene, personal protective equipment, sharps handling, biomedical waste, exposure response, cleaning and disinfection, lifting or patient movement, and emergency situations. Do not improvise a clinical or infection-control procedure because the office is busy.

Important skills

Employers often value:

- respectful patient communication;
- active listening and clear explanations;
- accurate documentation;

- confidentiality and discretion;
- attention to detail;
- reliable measurement and basic arithmetic;
- scheduling and organization;
- safe work habits;
- comfort with electronic health records and office systems;
- teamwork with clinicians and administrative staff;
- ability to follow written procedures;
- calm escalation when something falls outside your authority; and
- willingness to learn employer-specific workflows.

Bilingual communication can be useful in many communities, but workers should not claim professional medical-interpreter qualification unless they actually have the required preparation or credential. Follow employer rules for interpreter services when precise clinical communication is needed.

Education and entry pathways

United States

O*NET classifies Medical Assistants as **31-9092.00**. The U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics states that medical assistants typically need postsecondary education such as a certificate, although some enter with a high-school diploma and receive on-the-job training.

A practical entry sequence is:

1. Review current local job postings and note repeated education, credential, CPR, phlebotomy, EKG, electronic-health-record, and experience requirements.
2. Check your state's current rules and the employer's permitted scope before choosing a program.
3. Compare community college, public technical school, employer-sponsored, Registered Apprenticeship, workforce-funded, and private-program options.
4. Verify total tuition, fees, books, uniforms, equipment, clinical-placement requirements, exam costs, refund rules, and whether the program meets the eligibility requirements for any credential you intend to pursue.
5. Prefer supervised skills practice and legitimate clinical experience over programs that promise fast credentials without adequate hands-on preparation.
6. Apply for entry roles, apprenticeships, externships, or employer training that match your actual qualifications.

Certification can be preferred or required by some employers or jurisdictions, but there is no single credential that automatically grants the same scope everywhere in the United States. Before paying for an exam-preparation course, verify that the credential is requested by employers in your target area and that you meet the certifying body's current eligibility rules.

Registered Apprenticeship in the United States

Apprenticeship.gov lists **Medical Assistant** among high-demand healthcare Registered Apprenticeship occupations and provides a competency-based occupational framework. Registered Apprenticeship combines paid work, structured on-the-job learning, mentorship, related instruction, and progressive skill development.

Availability depends on employers and location. Search current opportunities rather than assuming a program exists in every area.

Canada — use duty-based comparisons, not a direct title transfer

Canada does not have one nationwide Job Bank occupation that exactly duplicates the U.S. Medical Assistant combination of administrative and delegated clinical tasks. A person exploring comparable work should identify the duties they actually want to perform.

Medical administrative assistant — NOC 13112. This occupation focuses on secretarial and administrative duties in medical settings. Job Bank reports that secondary school is usually required and a one- or two-year college program or other specialized medical-secretarial training is usually required. The current national median wage is approximately **CAD \$25.00 per hour**.

Medical office assistant / receptionist — NOC 14101. Job Bank maps Medical Office Assistant to Receptionists. This pathway focuses on reception, calls, appointments, and clerical duties. Secondary school is usually required and on-the-job training may be provided. The current national median wage is approximately **CAD \$21.00 per hour**.

Nurse aides, orderlies and patient service associates — NOC 33102. Some basic patient-care support duties may resemble part of a U.S. medical-assistant role, but this is a distinct occupation with different training and employment expectations. Job Bank currently reports a national median wage of approximately **CAD \$24.00 per hour**.

Do not present a U.S. Medical Assistant certificate as automatically equivalent to a Canadian credential or as authority to perform clinical duties in a province or territory. Verify the exact employer, training, regulatory, and delegated-practice rules for the role you want.

Colombia — a different occupational and regulatory structure

Colombia's OCUPACOL identifies **CUOC 42291 — Auxiliares administrativos en salud**. This occupation includes receiving and orienting users, supporting physicians administratively, processing admissions and health-record forms, and supporting billing and related administrative services.

Common titles include auxiliar administrativo en salud, auxiliar de admisiones hospitalarias, auxiliar de apoyo administrativo en salud, auxiliar de registro y admisiones en salud, and related user-service or billing positions.

Colombian rules also recognize **Auxiliar Administrativo en Salud** within the framework for auxiliary health personnel and occupational training. This is not permission to assume the clinical scope of a U.S. Medical Assistant. Verify current authorized-program status and the

applicable Ministry of Health, Ministry of Education, employer, and local requirements before enrolling or performing patient-care tasks.

SENA's Agencia Pública de Empleo shows current employer use of the title *Auxiliar administrativo en salud*. Recent 2026 vacancy examples included salary bands such as **COP \$1,500,001–\$2,000,000 per month** and **COP \$2,000,001–\$2,500,000 per month**, depending on the vacancy and required experience. These are examples from job postings, **not an official national wage statistic or a guaranteed salary**.

For public or low-cost training, start with current SENA/Betowa offerings and verify the exact program name, training centre, modality, formal authorization, admission conditions, and whether the program leads to the occupational qualification you need.

Latin America and the Caribbean

Occupation names and health-support scopes vary widely across the region. A role called *asistente médico*, *auxiliar de salud*, *auxiliar administrativo en salud*, *asistente de consultorio*, or a similar title may have very different duties and training rules from the U.S. occupation.

Use OIT/Cinterfor to identify the appropriate national vocational-training institution, then verify the country's current health and education regulators. Never assume that a U.S. certificate authorizes clinical practice in another country.

Free-first and lower-cost learning strategy

Before paying a private school, use a free-first sequence:

1. Read 15–20 current local job postings.
2. Write down the requirements that appear repeatedly.
3. Learn basic medical terminology, anatomy vocabulary, privacy principles, professional communication, and administrative workflow using reputable free study resources.
4. Ask public community colleges, technical schools, workforce centres, employers, hospitals, clinics, and apprenticeship sponsors about lower-cost or funded pathways.
5. Compare at least three programs using total cost rather than advertised tuition alone.
6. Verify whether clinical placement, externship, background screening, immunization, CPR, uniforms, supplies, or exam fees are included.
7. Pay for a private credential only after confirming that it is recognized by employers and that the program meets the eligibility requirements for any exam you plan to take.

Free online study can strengthen knowledge, but it does not replace supervised clinical skills training when the job requires hands-on procedures.

Funding and employer support

United States — WIOA and American Job Centers

CareerOneStop provides a WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder. If you may qualify for Workforce Innovation and Opportunity Act training services, contact your local American Job

Center and confirm whether a specific medical-assistant program is on the eligible-provider list.

WIOA eligibility and funding are not guaranteed. Do not enroll assuming reimbursement until the local workforce program has confirmed your eligibility and the approved training arrangement.

United States — employer support

Ask employers about:

- paid onboarding;
- medical-assistant Registered Apprenticeship;
- tuition assistance;
- externship-to-hire programs;
- exam or certification reimbursement;
- CPR or skills-course payment;
- uniforms or equipment support;
- paid cross-training; and
- internal advancement into scheduling, care coordination, specialty support, practice administration, phlebotomy, coding, or other roles for which you become qualified.

If employer funding has a repayment or minimum-service condition, obtain the terms in writing first.

Canada — student grants and loans

Eligible students in designated post-secondary programs may qualify for Canada Student Grants and Loans through their province or territory. For the **2026–27** school year, the Canada Student Grant for Full-Time Students can provide up to **CAD \$4,200 per year**, or up to **CAD \$525 per month of study**, subject to financial need and other eligibility rules.

Do not assume a program is eligible simply because it is healthcare-related. Verify the school and program through the appropriate provincial or territorial student-aid process before committing money.

Colombia and Latin America

In Colombia, check SENA/Betowa and other properly authorized public pathways before paying a private institution. In other Latin American countries, use OIT/Cinterfor to identify the national vocational-training system, then verify the current provider and health-training rules locally.

Income and employment outlook

United States — official current data

O*NET's national wage page reports **2025 BLS wage data** for Medical Assistants:

- **median hourly wage: USD \$21.97;**
- **median annual wage: USD \$45,690;**
- **10th percentile annual wage: USD \$36,050; and**
- **90th percentile annual wage: USD \$59,310.**

BLS Occupational Outlook Handbook reports approximately **811,000** Medical Assistant jobs in 2024 and projects approximately **912,200** in 2034, a **12%** increase. BLS projects about **112,300 openings per year**, on average, over 2024–2034.

The BLS OOH page's own May 2024 median is **USD \$44,200**. The Version 2 guide uses the newer 2025 BLS wage figure surfaced by O*NET for current compensation while retaining the OOH figure only as a clearly dated reference.

These are national statistics, not guaranteed starting wages. Pay varies by location, specialty, employer, schedule, experience, duties, and credentials.

United States — current non-government estimate

Salary.com reported an average U.S. Medical Assistant salary of approximately **USD \$45,918 per year / \$22 per hour** as of **August 1, 2026**, with a stated 25th–75th percentile annual range of approximately **USD \$41,684–\$50,505**.

This is a **private market estimate**, not an official government wage statistic. Methodology and job-title matching can differ from BLS data, so the figures should not be blended into one number.

Canada — official Job Bank comparison figures

Because Canada does not have one direct Medical Assistant equivalent, use the wage for the actual Canadian occupation being considered:

- Medical administrative assistant, NOC 13112: about **CAD \$25.00/hour median nationally;**
- Medical office assistant/receptionist, NOC 14101: about **CAD \$21.00/hour median nationally;** and
- Nurse aide/orderly/patient service associate, NOC 33102: about **CAD \$24.00/hour median nationally.**

Use Job Bank's province/territory and locality filters before making a training or relocation decision.

A practical 12-week start plan

Weeks 1–2: Review 15–20 local postings. Separate purely administrative medical-office roles from jobs requiring clinical skills. Record repeated credentials, software, CPR, phlebotomy, EKG, language, experience, and scheduling requirements.

Weeks 3–4: Study medical terminology, common abbreviations, basic anatomy vocabulary, professional communication, privacy, scheduling, and accurate documentation. Practice without using real patient data.

Weeks 5–6: Compare public, employer-sponsored, apprenticeship, community-college, and private training options. Verify total cost, clinical practice, externship, exam eligibility, refund rules, and financing terms.

Weeks 7–8: Complete only supervised safety and clinical-skills practice through an authorized program or employer. Focus on infection prevention, PPE, sharps safety, vital signs, room preparation, documentation, and escalation.

Weeks 9–10: Build job-search evidence: a clear résumé, accurate list of completed skills, training certificates actually earned, software exposure, language ability, and supervised clinical or administrative experience.

Weeks 11–12: Apply to roles that match your verified preparation. Prepare examples showing patient respect, confidentiality, accuracy, teamwork, safe escalation, and ability to follow procedures.

Building experience without overstating your scope

Useful transferable experience can come from:

- healthcare reception or scheduling;
- customer service in regulated settings;
- medical records or document processing;
- insurance or billing support;
- pharmacy or dental-office administration where duties are relevant;
- caregiving or patient-service work, when described accurately;
- community health outreach;
- inventory and supply support;
- supervised externships; and
- employer training.

Describe what you actually did. Do not turn observation into claimed hands-on experience or list a clinical task as independent competence when it was only practiced in a classroom or observed during an externship.

Career progression

With additional education, credentials, and experience, possible directions may include senior medical assistant, specialty medical assistant, lead medical assistant, care coordinator, patient access specialist, practice coordinator, medical administrative assistant, medical records specialist, phlebotomy-related work, coding/billing, or other healthcare-support occupations.

Some advanced roles have separate licensing or credential requirements. Verify them before investing in training.

Using AI responsibly in this work

AI can be useful for low-risk activities such as:

- explaining general medical terminology for study;
- creating practice interview questions;
- generating fictional documentation exercises;
- helping organize a non-sensitive study plan; or
- drafting a generic administrative checklist that is then checked against employer policy.

AI must **not** replace licensed clinical judgment, approved clinical instructions, medication orders, diagnosis, treatment decisions, emergency procedures, or employer-approved documentation systems.

Never paste patient names, dates of birth, addresses, medical-record numbers, insurance identifiers, diagnoses, test results, photographs, visit notes, appointment details, or other protected information into a public AI service unless the organization has explicitly authorized that system and use.

Verify AI-generated clinical terminology, calculations, citations, patient instructions, and administrative content against approved sources before using it. If an AI answer conflicts with a clinician's order, employer procedure, law, or approved reference, stop and escalate through the proper channel.

Cybersecurity and privacy basics

Medical offices handle highly sensitive information. Follow employer rules for:

- unique accounts and multifactor authentication;
- password and credential protection;
- screen locking;
- approved electronic health record access;
- minimum-necessary access to patient information;
- secure messaging and file sharing;
- phishing and suspicious attachments;
- verification of unusual payment, prescription, portal, or account-change requests;
- printing and disposal of records;
- portable devices and removable media;
- incident and privacy-event reporting; and
- use of personal devices, cloud storage, transcription tools, or AI services.

Do not look up a patient record out of curiosity or because you know the person. Access must be tied to authorized work.

Avoid scams and weak training programs

Be cautious when a school, recruiter, credential seller, or employer:

- guarantees employment or a specific salary;
- claims one private certificate authorizes every clinical task everywhere;
- says you can perform invasive procedures without supervised skills training;

- pressures you to enroll immediately;
- hides total tuition or financing terms;
- cannot explain externship or clinical-practice arrangements;
- will not show exam-eligibility requirements;
- promises a government license that does not exist for the program;
- asks you to pay for a job offer with gift cards, cryptocurrency, or unusual transfers; or
- requests sensitive identity, banking, or patient information before you have verified the organization.

Verify the school, credential, employer, and job independently before paying or sharing sensitive data.

When to pause before spending money

Pause enrollment when:

- local employers do not request the credential;
- you have not checked whether your state or jurisdiction limits the clinical tasks you want to perform;
- the school will not disclose total cost and refund terms;
- clinical practice is unclear or unsupervised;
- the program does not meet the current eligibility rules for an exam you intend to take;
- a public, apprenticeship, workforce-funded, or employer-paid option may cover the same preparation; or
- financing would create debt you cannot comfortably repay.

Current sources

Official/public sources:

- U.S. Department of Labor O*NET OnLine — Medical Assistants, 31-9092.00:
<https://www.onetonline.org/link/details/31-9092.00>
- O*NET / BLS 2025 national wage data — Medical Assistants:
<https://www.onetonline.org/link/localwages/31-9092.00>
- U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics — Occupational Outlook Handbook, Medical Assistants:
<https://www.bls.gov/ooh/healthcare/medical-assistants.htm>
- Apprenticeship.gov — Healthcare Registered Apprenticeship:
<https://www.apprenticeship.gov/apprenticeship-industries/healthcare>
- CareerOneStop — WIOA-Eligible Training Program Finder:
<https://www.careeronestop.org/LocalHelp/EmploymentAndTraining/find-WIOA-training-programs.aspx>
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Medical administrative assistant, NOC 13112:
<https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/summary-occupation/25791/ca>
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Medical administrative assistant requirements:
<https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/requirements/25791/ca>

- Government of Canada Job Bank — Medical office assistant / receptionist, NOC 14101: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/summary-occupation/24389/ca>
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Medical office assistant requirements: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/requirements/24389/ca>
- Government of Canada Job Bank — Nurse aides, orderlies and patient service associates, NOC 33102: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/summary-occupation/15798/ca>
- Government of Canada Job Bank — NOC 33102 requirements: <https://www.jobbank.gc.ca/marketreport/requirements/15798/ca>
- Government of Canada — Canada Student Grant for Full-Time Students: <https://www.canada.ca/en/services/benefits/education/student-aid/grants-loans/full-time.html>
- Government of Canada — apply for student grants/loans through province or territory: <https://www.canada.ca/en/services/benefits/education/student-aid/grants-loans/province-apply.html>
- Colombia Ministerio del Trabajo OCUPACOL — CUOC 42291 Auxiliares administrativos en salud: <https://ocupacol.mintrabajo.gov.co/Profile/OccupationalProfile/42291>
- SENA Normograma — Colombian auxiliary-health training/regulatory compilation: https://normograma.sena.edu.co/compilacion/docs/decreto_4904_2009.htm
- SENA Agencia Pública de Empleo: <https://agenciapublicadeempleo.sena.edu.co/>
- SENA Betowa training locator: <https://betowa.sena.edu.co/>
- OIT/Cinterfor regional vocational-training locator: <https://www.oitcinterfor.org/>

Supplementary non-government salary source:

- Salary.com — Medical Assistant salary, August 1, 2026: <https://www.salary.com/research/salary/opening/medical-assistant-salary>

Source and review note

This guide uses current-source research recorded on August 19, 2026. Occupation titles, delegated clinical duties, state/provincial/national rules, credentials, wages, training availability, funding, and employer requirements can change. Recheck official sources and current local job postings before making an education or employment decision.

This controlled revision was produced with AI assistance and auditable source review. It does **not** claim independent human certification, professional accreditation, certified translation, medical or legal review, financial advice, or guaranteed admission, credentialing, employment, salary, or promotion outcomes.